> Affairs… I told him that Reliance Industries was just 16 hours away from Mumbai, in Jamnagar, and oxygen tankers can come from there every night. He said that such an allocation cannot be made just for one city. I told him that he can allocate it to Maharashtra and I will make sure that it comes to Mumbai city only… And then 125 MT of oxygen was allocated to us from Jamnagar. The same evening, tankers started moving …[35] [36]

As a contrast to this experience, Maharashtra Chief Minister's Office (CMO), in response to dealing with the oxygen shortage in the state, announced on the same day that, 'Chief minister (Uddhav Thackeray) is trying to contact PM Modi on phone over shortage of oxygen and Remdesivir and he was informed that the Prime Minister is on Bengal tour'.[37] Several other opposition parties joined into this attack, fervently retweeting news articles quoting the CMO's statement. While petty politics of this nature was being played out, Chahal and the Union Cabinet Secretary were working out solutions to amplify Maharashtra's oxygen supply as evidenced by Chahal's aforementioned statements. The prime minister too, in the last week had chaired two comprehensive review meetings on the oxygen supply arrangements to the 12 high burden states (Maharashtra included) on 16 April[38] and 17 April[39]. Anyone who knows how the PMO of India works, especially a chief minister of a state, is well aware that a prime minister is never unavailable; he travels with a mobile office replete with a competent team and close aides along. However, the kerfuffle which followed in the media sensationalizing the prime minister's unavailability only with the intent to create a spicy story went on to demonstrate how baseless statements were made by senior political leaders who were completely ignorant of actual realities.



20 APRIL 2021

INDIA | 21,55,109 ACTIVE CASES | 1,84,032 DEATHS | 11.16 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

WORLD | 1,72,93,478 ACTIVE CASES | 31,81,145 DEATHS | 52.22 CRORE VACCINE DOSES